

THE INDIAN SALARY MONEY RESET

WHERE DID MY SALARY GO?

A practical 30-day system to

find money leaks, control spending,
handle EMIs, build savings
and create a wealth plan.

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The Indian Salary Money Reset: a practical 30-day system to find money leaks, control spending, handle EMIs, build savings and create a wealth plan.

WATCH OUT | PLEASE READ

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All people, salaries and case studies in this book are **fictional composite examples** created to teach a method. All rupee figures are illustrations, not targets or promises. Nothing here guarantees any return, saving or outcome.

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BEFORE YOU BEGIN

How to Use This Book

You do not need to read this book. You need to do it.

Most money books are read once and forgotten. This one is built like a **field manual plus workbook**. Almost every chapter ends with something to do: a number to find, a list to make, a transfer to set up. If you only read, nothing changes. If you do the exercises, even imperfectly, you will finish with a complete personal money map.

Keep three things beside you: last month's **bank statement**, your **UPI/credit-card history**, and a pen or a spreadsheet. Everything else is in these pages.

The colour-coded boxes

BEHAVIOUR

Research-backed ideas from behavioural economics and psychology.

INDIA DATA

Figures from RBI, SEBI, NPCI, MoSPI and other official sources, always with context on what the number does and does not tell you.

WEALTH LESSON

Documented public statements or behaviour of well-known wealthy people, used as examples, never as authority.

TRY THIS

A small action. Do it before moving on.

KEY IDEA

The one idea to keep if you forget everything else in the chapter.

A promise, and a refusal

The promise: by Day 30 you will know where your salary goes, where it *should* go, and you will have a system that keeps working when your motivation does not.

The refusal: this book will not promise you will “become rich”, will not name a “best mutual fund” or “top stock”, and will not sell you billionaire secrets. Money is personal, and anyone who promises guaranteed results is selling something.

INTRODUCTION

Salary Credited. Salary Gone.

The most common money question in India is not “where should I invest?” It is much simpler.

Here is a month that will feel familiar to millions of people:

Salary credited: ₹30,000

Where it went	Amount
Rent	₹8,000
Groceries	₹4,500
Travel to work	₹2,000
Family support	₹3,000
EMI	₹2,500
Food delivery	₹1,800
Subscriptions	₹700
Shopping	₹1,500
Miscellaneous	₹1,200
Small UPI payments, cabs, “quick” purchases	₹2,300
Outings and gifts	₹2,500
TOTAL	₹30,000

And somehow, by the 24th, the account is empty again.

Which expense made you poor?

Usually, none of them. There is rarely one ₹10,000 mistake. The real culprit is a **system** of small, recurring, emotional and unavoidable payments, all happening at once, none of which was ever given a job to do.

That is what this book is about. We will not start with definitions of mutual funds, assets and liabilities. We will start with the question that actually hurts: **where did my salary go?**

The SALARY RESET SYSTEM

The method has eleven steps in two halves. The first half, **SALARY**, repairs your cash flow. The second half, **RESET**, builds safety and long-term strength.

	Step	What you do
S	See where the money goes	Collect statements; make the invisible visible
A	Audit every expense	Categorise each transaction
L	Locate leaks and liabilities	Find recurring waste and heavy debt
A	Allocate before spending	Give every rupee a job on salary day
R	Reduce costly debt and waste	Cancel, renegotiate, repay in a smart order
Y	Your future gets paid first	Savings leave before lifestyle arrives
R	Reserve emergency money	Build a safety buffer, level by level
E	Establish goals	Decide what the money is <i>for</i>
S	Strengthen income	Grow what you earn, deliberately
E	Eliminate lifestyle inflation	Raises should widen the gap, not the bills
T	Track and repeat	Ten minutes a month, forever

KEY IDEA

Income growth does not automatically create wealth. The **gap between income and spending** creates financial capacity. This book is about that gap.

Why this matters now

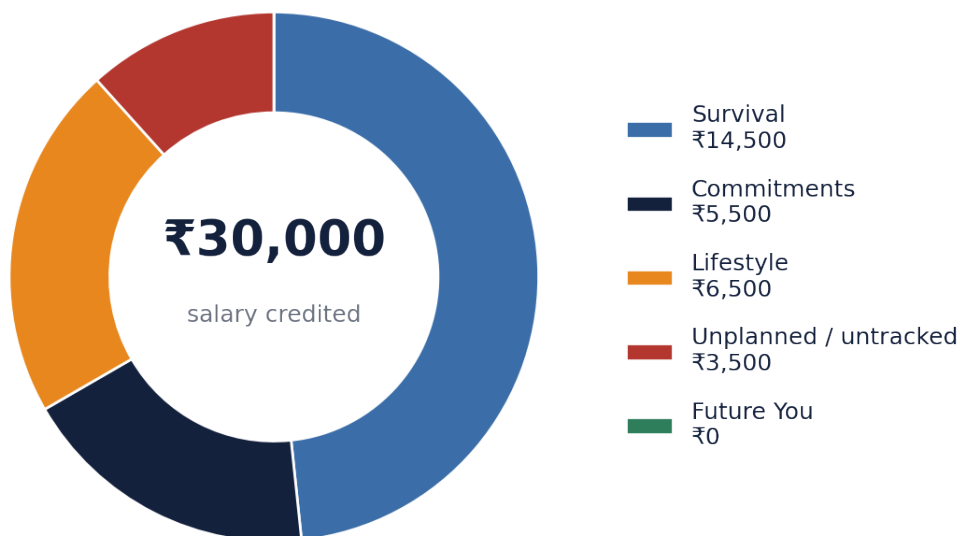
INDIA DATA | SEBI Investor Survey 2025

SEBI's **Investor Survey 2025** (released January 2026) reported that Indian households set aside roughly a quarter of monthly income for savings and investments combined, about 15% as savings and 9% as investments. It also found that only about 36% of securities-market investors showed moderate or high knowledge of market products.

What this means: a descriptive snapshot of how surveyed households behave. *What it does not mean:* it is not a target for your household. See the Sources appendix.

The lesson is not that people are careless. It is that knowing you *should* save or invest is different from knowing how to manage the money that actually reaches your bank account. That is the gap this book fills.

Where one month's salary actually went



Priya's ₹30,000 (fictional example): five destinations, and nothing reached Future You.

REAL LIFE | Month-end broke

Problem: "I earn ₹30,000, I'm not buying anything big, and I'm broke by the 24th."

Why it happens: your money leaves in small streams to *Survival*, *Commitments*, *Lifestyle* and *Unplanned*, and the fifth stream, *Future You*, is not connected to the tap.

The fix: connect *Future You* first, on salary day, before any other stream opens. That single reorder is the backbone of this book.

KEY IDEA

Start here: your 3-number dashboard. By the end of the Salary Autopsy (Chapter 2) you will know three numbers that tell you most of what you need to know about your money:

- **Leak Score:** what share of your salary escapes through recurring, unnecessary spending.
- **EMI Burden:** what share of your salary is already promised to lenders.
- **Runway:** how many months of essentials your safety buffer could cover.

WORKSHEET | My starting numbers (write your best guess now, the real figures later)

Number	My guess	My real figure (after Chapter 2)
Leak Score (%)		
EMI Burden (%)		
Runway (months)		

Your salary isn't disappearing.
You're spending it before
giving it a job.

WHERE DID MY SALARY GO?
#SalaryReset30

₹199 doesn't look dangerous.
₹199 × 12 does.

WHERE DID MY SALARY GO?
#SalaryReset30

You don't need a bigger salary first.
You need to see the salary
you already have.

WHERE DID MY SALARY GO?
#SalaryReset30

PART I

Why Your Salary Disappears

Before fixing anything, we learn to see.

Your Salary Didn't Disappear

It went somewhere. You just never told it where to go.

Money does not vanish. Every rupee that leaves your account lands in one of five places. Learning these five destinations is the first step to controlling them.

Destination	What lives here	Examples
Survival	Things you need to function	Rent, food, transport, electricity, mobile and internet
Commitments	Payments you are bound to make	EMIs, family support, school fees, insurance premiums
Lifestyle	Things that make life enjoyable (or merely convenient)	Eating out, shopping, OTT apps, trips, gadgets
Future You	Money that protects or grows your future	Emergency fund, savings, investments, goal funds
Unplanned	Real but unpredictable costs	Medical bills, repairs, gifts, festivals, travel at short notice

Most people's money flows to the first three in that order, and **Future You** gets whatever is left. In most months, nothing is left.

The problem is not necessarily that you spend too much. The problem may be that **your money has no assignment**.

Your salary isn't disappearing. You're spending it before giving it a job.

The five-minute honesty test

Without looking at any statement, answer from memory. Write numbers even if you are guessing:

WORKSHEET | Guess first, check later

Question	My guess
How much did I spend on food delivery and eating out last month?	
How many subscriptions am I paying for?	
How much did I pay in EMIs and credit-card dues?	
How much went to family, all included?	
How much did I save or invest?	
How much was spent that I cannot explain?	

Keep this page. In the next chapter you will compare your guesses with the real numbers. For most people the gap is the most surprising moment in the whole book.

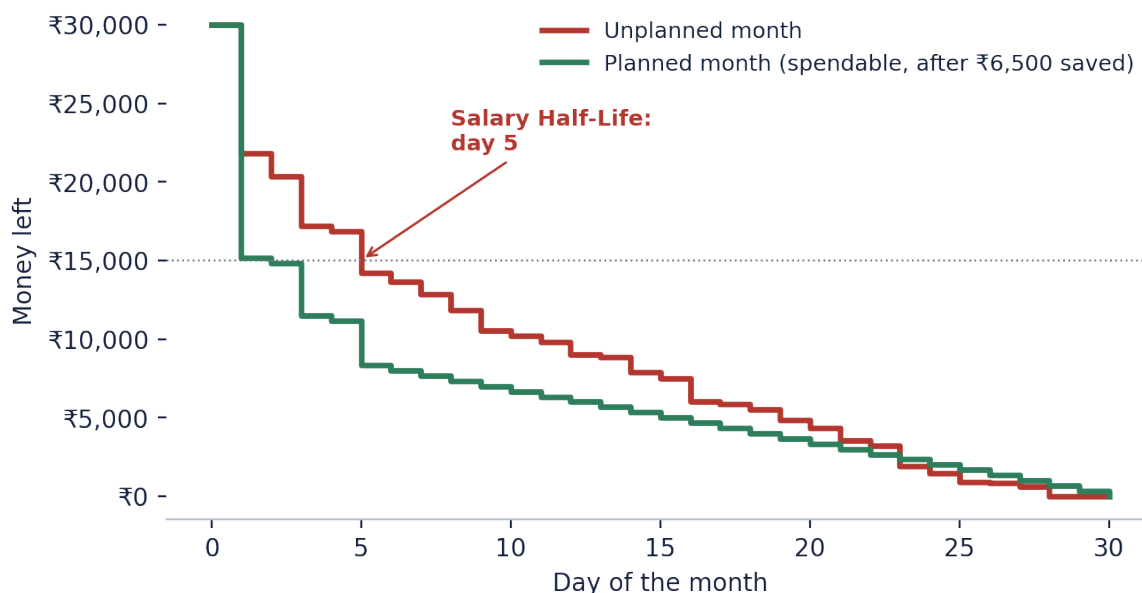
ORIGINAL METRIC | Salary Half-Life

Salary Half-Life = the day of the month on which half your take-home pay has left your account.

In Priya's unplanned month it was **day 5**. Rent, family support and the EMI go out in the first days, and by the fifth, half her salary was gone, with 25 days still to live. Most people have never measured this, and it explains why the second half of the month feels like surviving instead of living.

Your move: find your own half-life from last month's statement. Then spread, delay or pre-fund the big outflows (see Chapter 8) so your half-life moves toward the middle of the month.

A salary balance across 30 days (illustrative)



Illustrative curve built from Priya's example month. Your own statement will look different.

SHARE THIS

“My salary’s half-life is day 5.” Calculate yours and tell people. It is a number that makes people ask, “What’s mine?”

CHAPTER 2

The 30-Minute Salary Autopsy

A calm, judgement-free post-mortem of last month.

An autopsy is not about blame. It is about finding out what actually happened. Set a timer for 30 minutes and gather these:

- Last month’s **bank statement** (download the PDF or CSV from your bank app)
- **UPI history** from every app you use
- **Credit-card statement(s)**
- **Cash withdrawals** (ATM entries on the statement)
- **Wallet** transactions and prepaid balances
- Active **subscriptions** (check app-store subscription pages and card statements)
- Your **EMI schedule** and loan statements

Step 1: Categorise every transaction

Go line by line. For each transaction, answer five questions:

Expense	Amount	Necessary?	Recurring?	Emotional?	Can reduce?
Rent	₹8,000	Yes	Yes	No	Low
Food delivery	₹1,800	No	Yes	Sometimes	High
Subscriptions	₹700	No	Yes	No	High
EMI	₹2,500	Yes	Yes	No	Medium

“Emotional?” is the honest column. Did you buy it because you needed it, or because you were tired, stressed, bored, celebrating or comparing? You are not being asked to feel guilty, only to notice.

Step 2: Calculate your Money Leak Score

KEY IDEA

Money Leak Score = (recurring unnecessary expenses ÷ take-home salary) × 100

Example: ₹3,000 ÷ ₹30,000 = **10%**.

This is your personal diagnostic number, not an academic standard. Its purpose is to turn “I wasted a few hundred rupees” into “I am potentially losing 10% of my salary every month.”

Be honest but fair. Count only expenses that are both *recurring* and ones you would *choose to cut* if you looked at them clearly. A coffee with a friend you enjoy is not a leak. A forgotten ₹499 subscription is.

Priya’s autopsy (a fictional example)

Priya, 27, works in Bengaluru and takes home ₹30,000. Her statements show:

Item	Amount	Reducible?
Rent	₹8,000	Low
Groceries	₹4,500	Medium
Travel to work	₹2,000	Low
Family support	₹3,000	Planned
EMI (phone)	₹2,500	Fixed
Food delivery	₹1,800	High
Subscriptions	₹700	High
Shopping	₹1,500	High
Miscellaneous	₹1,200	Medium
Small UPI payments and cabs	₹2,300	Medium
Outings and gifts	₹2,500	Medium

Recurring unnecessary spending: delivery (₹1,800) + subscriptions (₹700) + impulse shopping (₹1,500) = **₹4,000**.

Leak Score: ₹4,000 ÷ ₹30,000 = **13.3%**. Over a year, that is **₹48,000**.

Priya’s reaction: “*I thought I was wasting a few hundred here and there.*” The number, not willpower, changes behaviour.

WORKSHEET | Your Salary Autopsy (copy this table into a notebook or spreadsheet for all your transactions)

Expense	Amount	Necessary?	Recurring?	Emotional?	Can reduce?

WORKSHEET | My Money Leak Score

Line	My number
Take-home salary	
Recurring unnecessary expenses (monthly)	
Leak Score = $(B \div A) \times 100 = __\%$	
Annual leakage = $B \times 12$	

TRY THIS

Compare the statement with your guesses from Chapter 1. Circle the biggest surprise. That surprise is where your first month of progress will come from.

REAL LIFE | “No time” fix

Problem: “I don’t have time to go through statements.”

The fix in 20 minutes, not 3 hours: (1) download only *one* month, (2) sort by amount, descending, (3) label the top 15 transactions, which usually cover 70% or more of the money, (4) then scan the rest only for repeats of the same name. You are hunting for repeats, not for every rupee.

Bonus: search your statement for the words *Swiggy, Zomato, Blinkit, Amazon, Netflix, Prime, Google, Apple, Cred, Paytm* and your own frequent merchants. Add each total. That is your quick-and-dirty leak list.

CHAPTER 3

The ₹100 Problem

Why small amounts feel harmless and add up like big ones.

Look at a normal Tuesday:

Moment	Amount
Second coffee	₹80
Delivery fee on lunch	₹149
App subscription renewed	₹99
Evening snack	₹120
Cab “upgrade”	₹199
Impulse add-to-cart	₹249

Not one of these feels important. That is exactly why they work so well on your wallet.

Annualise everything

Our brains judge a price by the number we see. A recurring charge shows a small number.

Multiply it by twelve and the picture changes.

Monthly price	Per year
₹199	₹2,388
₹499	₹5,988
₹799	₹9,588
₹999	₹11,988
₹1,800 (delivery habit)	₹21,600

And the small habits: ₹150 × 20 occasions = ₹3,000 a month = **₹36,000 a year.**

₹199 doesn't look dangerous. ₹199 × 12 does.

BEHAVIOUR

Researchers describe **mental accounting**: people sort money into mental categories and treat small, frequent amounts differently from large one-off ones, even though rupees are rupees. A ₹100 spend feels like “pocket change”, while the same ₹3,000 in one go would trigger a pause.

TRY THIS

For every recurring charge you have, write the annual figure next to it. Ask one question: “Would I pay ₹5,988 once, today, for this?” If the answer is no, cancel or reduce it.

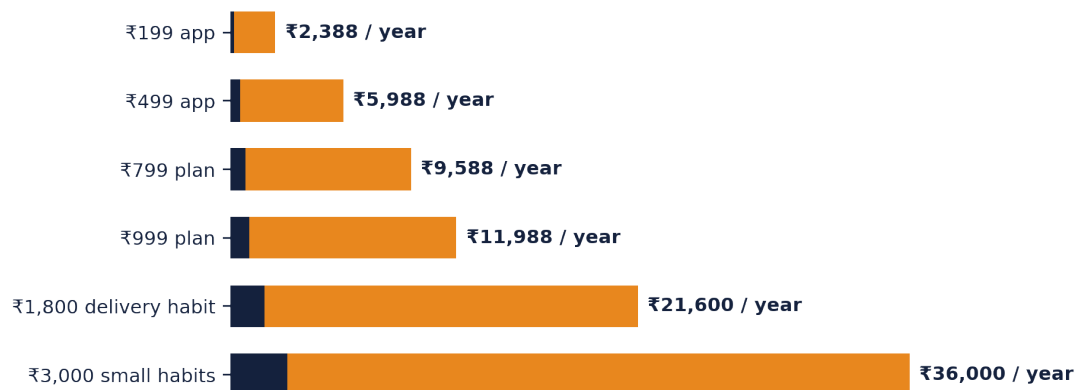
ORIGINAL METRIC | Hourly Life Cost

Hourly Life Cost = price ÷ what you earn per working hour.

On a ₹30,000 take-home and about 208 working hours a month, one hour of your life earns about **₹144** (after deductions). Now price things in hours:

Purchase	Price	Hours of your life
₹999 plan, per year	₹11,988	83 hours
Food-delivery habit, per year	₹21,600	150 hours (about 19 working days)
A ₹25,000 phone	₹25,000	173 hours (about 22 working days)
A ₹500 impulse order	₹500	3.5 hours

Monthly (navy) vs yearly (orange): same spend, different feeling



The same spending, felt monthly (navy) vs yearly (orange).

SHARE THIS

“That ₹25,000 phone costs me 173 hours of work.” Ask your audience: how many hours is yours?

The UPI Illusion

Payments got easier. Seeing the total did not.

UPI is one of the best things to happen to Indian everyday finance: instant, cheap and universal. This chapter is not against UPI. It is about a side effect of any frictionless payment: **the individual transaction feels smaller than the monthly total.**

INDIA DATA

NPCI publishes monthly UPI statistics, and the volumes run into billions of transactions a month. That shows how deeply digital payments are woven into daily life. It does **not** prove UPI causes overspending, and this book does not claim it does. Check NPCI's product-statistics page for the latest figures.

Digital payments can make each transaction feel less tangible. Your statement reveals the cumulative amount. Typical small-UPI categories to watch:

- ₹50–₹200 payments: tea, snacks, auto, tolls, parking
- Food delivery, plus platform, delivery and “small order” fees
- Quick-commerce top-ups and “just one thing” orders
- Cab and auto upgrades, surge and tips
- Online shopping and flash sales
- App subscriptions and auto-renewals
- Gaming and in-app digital purchases
- Convenience fees, and small transfers to friends that never come back

The 7-Day UPI Audit

For seven days, open your UPI app each night and note every payment. At the end, add up:

WORKSHEET | 7-Day UPI Audit

Measure	My number
Total UPI spent in 7 days: ₹	
Number of transactions	
Non-essential transactions	
Potentially reducible amount: ₹	
Multiply reducible amount by 4 (monthly estimate) ₹	

KEY IDEA

The real enemy may not be your ₹50 coffee. It may be the 40 transactions you forgot you made.

Three low-effort frictions

- **Move the apps.** Take shopping and delivery apps off your home screen.
- **Weekly spending wallet.** Transfer your weekly “enjoy” amount to a separate account or UPI-linked bank, and spend only from it.
- **Turn off one-tap saved cards** on apps where you overspend, so every purchase takes a few more seconds.

100 squares = ₹30,000 (1 square = ₹300). Future You got zero.



Each square is ₹300. The red squares are small, forgotten spending, about 12% of the salary.

REAL LIFE | The “just one thing” trap

Problem: “Quick-commerce is only a few items. How can that be my problem?”

What the audit usually shows: the order value is small, so you add a small delivery, handling or “small-cart” fee, a tip, and one extra item you did not plan. Do that on ten evenings and you have paid for a week of groceries in fees and extras.

The fix: one **weekly bulk list** for staples, and a rule that quick-commerce is allowed only for genuinely urgent needs. Set the app’s monthly limit in your Can Enjoy bucket and delete the saved card if you have to.

The Lifestyle Inflation Trap

You got a raise. Why do you still have nothing?

Lifestyle inflation is the quiet habit of raising your spending every time your income rises, until the gap between the two never grows. Watch it happen with one product, the phone:

Salary	Phone bought	Phone as a share of one month's salary
₹25,000	₹10,000	40%
₹40,000	₹25,000	62.5%
₹60,000	₹45,000	75%

Salary more than doubled. The phone got more expensive faster. And phone is only one line: it is usually joined by rent, vehicle, dining and travel moving up the ladder at the same time.

KEY IDEA

Income growth does not automatically create wealth. The gap between income and spending creates financial capacity.

The Raise Rule

Decide in advance how a raise will be used, **before** it arrives, because after it arrives, every expense will suddenly seem justified. One simple approach many people use:

Share of the raise	Goes to
About half	Future You (emergency fund, savings, investments, debt repayment)
About a third	Lifestyle upgrades you actually chose
The rest	Family, flexibility, irregular expenses

These proportions are an example, not a rule. Choose your own, write them down, and keep them.

BEHAVIOUR

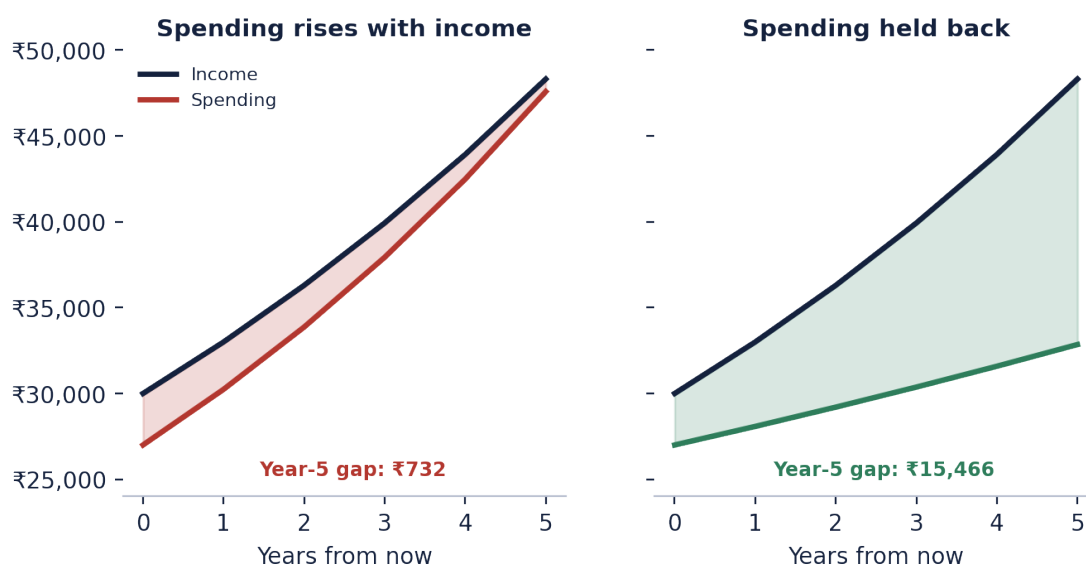
Social comparison and **reward spending** ("I worked hard, I deserve it") are two of the strongest drivers of lifestyle inflation. Deserving something and being able to afford it are different questions, and both deserve an honest answer.

WORKSHEET | Lifestyle Inflation Check

	Two years ago	Now
Take-home salary		
Total monthly spending		
Monthly gap (income – spending)		
Total debt payments		
Money in emergency fund		

If your income grew and the gap did not, you have found your inflation.

Same raises, very different wealth (illustrative: income +10%/yr; spending +12% vs +4%)



Both people get the same raises. Only the second one builds wealth.

ORIGINAL METRIC | Raise Capture Rate

Raise Capture Rate = (new monthly surplus – old monthly surplus) ÷ raise × 100.

Example A: salary goes from ₹30,000 to ₹40,000 (a ₹10,000 raise). Spending jumps from ₹25,000 to ₹37,000. Surplus falls from ₹5,000 to ₹3,000. Capture rate: $(3,000 - 5,000) \div 10,000 = -20\%$. The raise made the person *poorer*.

Example B: same raise, but spending only rises to ₹28,000. Surplus is ₹12,000. Capture rate: $(12,000 - 5,000) \div 10,000 = 70\%$.

Your move: before your next raise, pick your target capture rate. Many people find 50% a realistic, motivating starting point.

SHARE THIS

“My last raise had a Raise Capture Rate of ____%.” Simple, personal, and a perfect comment prompt.

Myth vs Evidence

Five popular beliefs, and what is actually true.

WATCH OUT

Myth: “High income automatically creates wealth.”

KEY IDEA

Reality: Income is one input. Spending, debt, savings, assets, time and behaviour matter just as much. A ₹1 lakh salary with ₹1 lakh spending builds nothing.

WATCH OUT

Myth: “You need a high salary to start saving.”

KEY IDEA

Reality: The amount can be small. The vital question is whether a repeatable system exists. ₹500 saved every salary day is a system. ₹50,000 saved once is a windfall.

WATCH OUT

Myth: “Every investment should maximise returns.”

KEY IDEA

Reality: Risk, liquidity, time horizon and *purpose* matter. Emergency money exists for availability, not return.

WATCH OUT

Myth: “Budgeting means saying no to everything.”

KEY IDEA

Reality: A useful budget deliberately includes spending for enjoyment. Budgets that ban fun get abandoned in week three.

WATCH OUT

Myth: “The 50/30/20 rule works for everyone.”

KEY IDEA

Reality: Household circumstances differ enormously, as the next part will show.

PART II

Repair Your Cash Flow

Give every rupee a job, then protect the plan.

The Flexible 5-Bucket System

Stop using the 50/30/20 rule as a religion.

Popular budgeting rules suggest fixed percentages for needs, wants and savings. They are helpful starting points, but there is **no magic percentage that works for every Indian household**. Someone earning ₹20,000 with rent and family responsibilities cannot use the same split as someone earning ₹1,00,000 with no dependents.

So this book does the opposite: **audit first, then decide the percentages**. Your Salary Autopsy from Chapter 2 gives you the real numbers. Now you sort them into five buckets.

Bucket	What goes inside	Purpose
1. Must Live	Housing, food, utilities, transport	Keeps life running
2. Must Pay	EMIs, family obligations, essential insurance, required payments	Honours commitments
3. Must Protect	Emergency savings plus an irregular-expenses fund	Stops surprises becoming debt
4. Must Build	Long-term investments and goal funds	Future You
5. Can Enjoy	Eating out, shopping, entertainment, hobbies	Keeps the plan sustainable

KEY IDEA

A budget that includes guilt-free enjoyment is more likely to survive. Bucket 5 is not a reward for finishing the budget. It is part of the budget.

How to set your own percentages

- **Fill Buckets 1 and 2 first** from your real numbers. They are your fixed floor.
- **Add what is left** (take-home minus Buckets 1 and 2) and call it your **Flexible Pool**.
- **Split the Flexible Pool** across Buckets 3, 4 and 5. In the early months, tilt towards Protect (the safety buffer). Once that has some depth, tilt towards Build.
- **Review every three months**. The plan should change when your life changes.

Same method, different salaries (illustration only)

These are *sample* allocations to show the logic. Your own numbers will differ.

Take-home	Must Live	Must Pay	Must Protect	Must Build	Can Enjoy
₹20,000	₹9,000	₹5,000	₹3,000	₹500	₹2,500
₹30,000	₹14,500	₹5,500	₹4,500	₹2,000	₹3,500
₹50,000	₹22,000	₹17,000	₹4,500	₹1,500	₹5,000

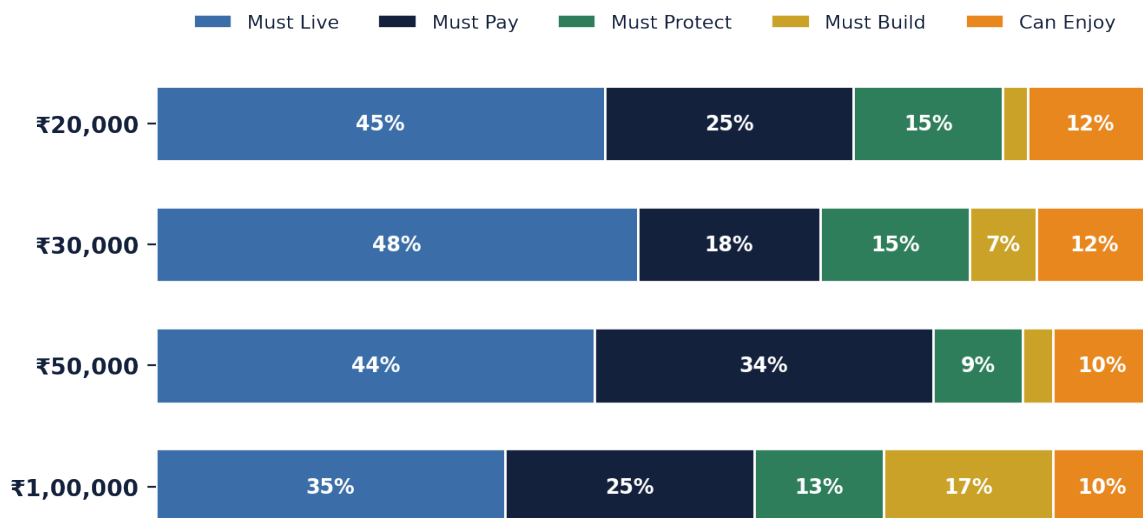
Take-home	Must Live	Must Pay	Must Protect	Must Build	Can Enjoy
₹1,00,000	₹35,000	₹25,000	₹13,000	₹17,000	₹10,000

Notice that the ₹50,000 salary in this illustration carries heavy commitments (loans and family), so its Build bucket is small. The case studies later in the book explain why.

WORKSHEET | My Five Buckets

Bucket	Monthly amount	% of take-home
Take-home salary		
1. Must Live		
2. Must Pay		
3. Must Protect		
4. Must Build		
5. Can Enjoy		

Check: buckets 1 to 5 must add up exactly to your take-home salary. Every rupee needs an assignment.



The same five buckets at four salaries: the proportions shift, the logic does not.

REAL LIFE | High rent, low flexibility

Problem: “My rent alone is 40% of my salary. The budget is impossible.”

The fix: do not force the textbook percentages. Keep Must Live honest, then look at the other levers: (1) the income side, with a side project or a skill that raises your pay, (2) a flatmate or shift in location when the lease ends, (3) shrinking Can Enjoy rather than Protect. A 40% rent bucket is a real constraint, but a ten-percent Protect bucket still beats none.

The Salary-Day Rule

Earn → Allocate → Protect → Spend.

Most people live by **Earn → Spend → Save what remains**. By the end of the month, nothing remains. The Salary-Day Rule reverses the order:

Earn → Allocate → Protect → Spend

On salary day, within 24 hours of the credit:

1. **Identify required bills** (rent, EMIs, utilities, insurance due this month).
2. **Transfer the planned savings amount** to a separate savings account or your goal funds.
3. **Fund the safety buffer** and irregular-expenses fund.
4. **Allocate discretionary spending**: move your Can Enjoy amount to a spending wallet or account.
5. **Spend only what is left** in the assigned bucket. When it is empty, it is empty.

Automation: use it, but know its limits

BEHAVIOUR

Behavioural research supports automation and defaults: studies of automatic enrolment in retirement plans found it can raise saving participation. More recent work also suggests the long-run effects can be smaller than early estimates, partly because some people offset by borrowing more elsewhere. Automation is a helpful tool, **not a guarantee**.

The principle holds: **reduce reliance on willpower**. Set up standing instructions so the transfer happens before you can argue with yourself.

- Standing instruction from salary account to savings account on the day after credit
- Automatic transfer to the emergency-fund account
- SIP or recurring deposit set for a few days after salary (only where you have decided the product is suitable)
- A calendar reminder for annual premiums and fees

WATCH OUT

Automate only an amount you can sustain. If an auto-debit fails because the balance is short, you may face charges. Start small, and increase after you have seen two clean months.

WORKSHEET | My Salary-Day Checklist

Task	Amount	Done on (date)
Pay rent / EMI / bills		
Transfer to Safety Buffer		
Transfer to Irregular-Expenses Fund		
Transfer to Build (goals/investments)		
Move Can Enjoy to spending wallet		
Family support sent		



The Salary-Day Rule at a glance.

REAL LIFE | First-week crunch

Problem: “Every month, rent, EMIs and bills hit in the first week and I run dry by the 18th.”

The fix: three small moves. (1) Ask whether any due dates can move to align with your salary date: many lenders and utilities allow it. (2) Split your Can Enjoy money into four weekly amounts and move each in on its own Monday. (3) Keep one month’s rent-equivalent as a *one-month-ahead* goal, so you are paying this month’s bills from last month’s money. That last step is worth working toward, and it removes the “salary delay” panic.

CHAPTER 9

Bills and Subscriptions

The easiest money you will ever find is the money you already forgot you were paying.

A recurring charge is a decision you made once and then paid for repeatedly without deciding again. That makes subscriptions and auto-renewals the best place to start trimming.

The Annual Subscription Audit

List every recurring charge from your bank, UPI auto-pay, credit card and the subscription pages of your phone's app store. Then:

Subscription	Monthly	Annual	Used last 30 days?	Keep / Cancel / Downgrade
Streaming app A	₹199	₹2,388	2 times	Downgrade or pause
Music app	₹119	₹1,428	Daily	Keep
Gym membership	₹1,000	₹12,000	0 times	Cancel
News / learning app	₹299	₹3,588	Never	Cancel

(Fictional example prices.) A “few small apps” may easily add up to a four-figure annual amount for things you barely use.

WORKSHEET | My Subscription Audit

Subscription	Monthly	Annual	Used in 30 days?	Decision

Five ways to cut bills without feeling poorer

- **Rotate, don't stack.** Keep one streaming service at a time, and switch monthly.
- **Call your providers.** Mobile, broadband and electricity plans change; ask about cheaper plans.
- **Check auto-pay mandates** in your UPI and bank apps. Cancel the ones you no longer use.
- **Pay on time.** Late fees and interest are the most pointless money you can spend.
- **Annual vs monthly.** If you are certain you will use a service all year, annual plans are often cheaper. If you are not certain, stay monthly.

TRY THIS

Cancel one subscription right now, before you finish this chapter. You can always resubscribe. Put its monthly amount into your first Protect transfer.

CHAPTER 10

EMI: The Silent Salary Eater

A small EMI feels harmless on the day you sign. Month after month, it takes first.

EMIs are not evil. A home loan, an education loan or a vehicle you truly need can be reasonable. The problem is the combined weight of several EMIs that you stopped noticing.

The EMI Burden

KEY IDEA

EMI Burden = total monthly debt payments ÷ take-home income × 100

Take-home ₹40,000	Monthly payment
Personal loan EMI	₹7,000
Phone EMI	₹2,000
Credit-card repayment	₹4,000
Total debt payments	₹13,000
EMI Burden	32.5%

A third of the salary is gone before the first grocery bill. The reader sees the problem immediately, and so should you.

WORKSHEET | My EMI Burden

Line	Amount
Take-home pay (A)	
Total EMIs and loan payments	
Credit-card repayments / minimums	
Buy-now-pay-later, hand loans, other dues	
Total debt payments (B)	
EMI Burden = $B \div A \times 100 = __\%$	

Sort your debt: Red, Yellow, Green

Colour	Type	How to treat it
Red	High-cost or revolving debt: credit-card balances carried over, short-term personal loans, loans from unregulated lenders, instant-loan apps	Top priority. Stop adding to it. Pay it down first (after a small safety buffer).
Yellow	Medium-cost consumer debt: gadget and appliance EMIs, vehicle loans	Pay on schedule. Avoid new ones. Consider prepaying if cost is high and terms allow.
Green	Lower-cost debt where you have a clear repayment plan: for example education or home loans	Keep paying; do not rush to prepay at the cost of your safety buffer.

WATCH OUT

Check the annual interest rate on your credit-card statement and loan documents. Card interest on balances carried over is typically among the most expensive borrowing you can have. If you can pay the full statement balance every month, you will generally avoid that interest. If you cannot, treat the balance as Red debt.

Two ways to order your repayments

- **Highest-interest-first** (often called the avalanche method): pay minimums on everything, send the extra to the debt with the highest interest rate. Mathematically cheapest.
- **Smallest-balance-first** (the snowball method): clear the smallest debt first for quick wins. Slightly more expensive, but some people stay motivated better.

Either works if you stick with it. The book does not tell you to “pay everything immediately”. Compare interest cost, liquidity and the contract terms, since some loans have prepayment charges, and keep a small buffer so that an emergency does not push you back to borrowing.

TRY THIS

List each loan: lender, outstanding amount, interest rate, EMI, months remaining. Colour each Red, Yellow or Green. Circle the one to attack first.

WORKSHEET | Debt Map

Lender / loan	Outstanding	Rate (%)	EMI	Months left	Colour

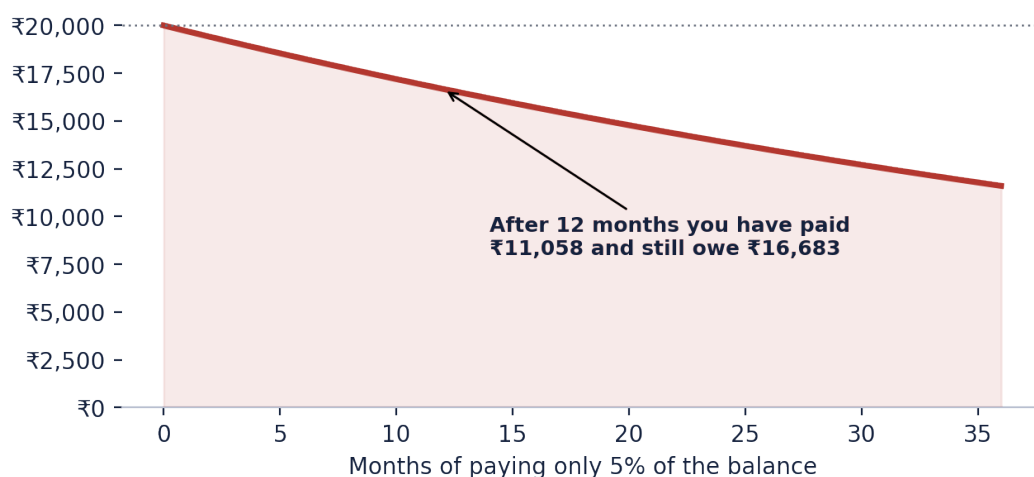
A ₹40,000 take-home, before the first grocery bill

EMI Burden: 32.5%



The picture of an EMI Burden of 32.5%.

The minimum-payment trap (hypothetical ₹20,000 at 3.5% a month)



Hypothetical numbers, to show the shape. Check your own card's interest rate and billing terms.

REAL LIFE | Minimum-payment trap

Problem: “I only pay the minimum due, so it’s under control.”

What the maths shows: in the hypothetical above, paying 5% of the balance each month for a year means paying about ₹11,000 while still owing about ₹16,700. The minimum keeps the account “good” and the debt alive.

The fix: pay the *full statement balance* if you can. If you cannot, treat the balance as Red debt, stop adding purchases to that card, and ask your bank about conversion to a fixed-term EMI at a lower rate. Compare the rate and any fees in writing before agreeing.

CHAPTER 11

Family Money Is Still Money

In India, your salary rarely belongs only to you. A good plan accepts that.

Parents, siblings’ education, weddings, festivals, medical help, a relative’s “temporary” request. These are real obligations and often meaningful acts of love. Western budgeting books ignore them. This one will not.

We will not say “*stop giving money to family.*” We will say: **budget for it, so it never forces you into a guilty decision.**

The Family Support Budget

Take-home ₹35,000	Monthly
Planned regular support (parents/household)	₹4,000
Family emergency reserve (kept aside for requests)	₹1,000
Total planned family allocation	₹5,000

That is about 14% of take-home. Yours might be 5% or 40%. The percentage is not the point. The point is that it is **planned, visible and finite.**

When a request arrives

- **Check the reserve.** If there is money in it, you can say yes without panic.
- **If the reserve is empty,** you can honestly say: “This month’s family budget is used. Can we plan for next month?” That is a plan, not a refusal.
- **Lend only what you can afford to never see again.** Treat large lending as a gift.
- **Talk early and kindly.** Share, at least with the household’s decision-makers, the idea of a monthly family budget, so surprises become rarer.

TRY THIS

Write down the family support you gave last month, including the small ones you did not count. Then decide on a monthly planned amount and a reserve, and put it in Bucket 2.

WORKSHEET | My Family Support Budget

Item	Monthly amount
Regular household support	
Education / medical support	
Festival and wedding fund (annual ÷ 12)	
Family emergency reserve	
Total	

REAL LIFE | Saying no, kindly

Problem: a relative asks for ₹50,000 you cannot spare.

A script that works: *"I'd like to help, and I've set a monthly limit for family support so I don't fall into debt myself. This month's family budget has ₹___ left. I can give that now, or help you think about other options."* You are kind, specific, and not apologising for having a plan.

PART III

Build Financial Safety

Before you grow money, make sure one bad month cannot destroy it.

Your Safety Buffer, Level by Level

Not “save six months”. A ladder you can actually climb.

The usual advice, “build an emergency fund of six months of expenses”, is sensible and also demoralising if you earn ₹20,000. So we build the buffer in **levels**:

Level	Target	What it protects against
1	₹5,000 starter	A phone repair, a small medical bill, a missed payment
2	₹25,000 safety buffer	A larger medical or travel emergency without borrowing
3	1 month of essential expenses	A short gap between jobs, or a delayed salary
4	3 months of essential expenses	A real job disruption
5	Increase as needed	Job instability, dependents, health, self-employment

Take whichever level you reach first. Do not wait to be at Level 4 before you celebrate Level 1.

KEY IDEA

An emergency fund is **not** an investment account. Its job is liquidity and resilience, not maximum return. Keep it somewhere safe and quickly accessible, such as a separate savings account, and check current options and rates yourself.

The Emergency Fund Calculator

Essential monthly expenses × chosen number of months = target.

Example: essentials of ₹18,000 (rent, food, utilities, transport, minimum EMIs) × 3 = **₹54,000.**

WORKSHEET | My Safety Buffer

Line	My number
Essential monthly expenses (A)	
Months I am aiming for (B)	
Target = A × B	
Already saved	
Monthly transfer → months to reach target	

What counts as a real emergency?

Emergency	Not an emergency
Medical and urgent health costs	A sale on something you wanted
Sudden job loss or income gap	A weekend trip with friends
Essential repair (home, vehicle used for work)	An upgrade you can plan for
Urgent travel for family crisis	Festival shopping (that goes in your irregular fund)

TRY THIS

Rule of thumb: if it was predictable, it is an irregular expense (Chapter 14). If it was unpredictable *and* urgent *and* important, it is an emergency. Before touching the fund, pause for a day. Then refill it first when you can.



Climb one rung at a time. Celebrate each one.

REAL LIFE | “The fund got used”

Problem: “I built ₹25,000, then a medical bill took it. What’s the point?”

Reframe: that is exactly the point. Without it, the bill goes on a card at a high interest rate. The buffer did its job. Refill it first, even ₹500 at a time.

Insurance and Protection Basics

Protection is not exciting. That is the point.

A single hospital stay or loss of income can erase years of saving. Insurance transfers part of that risk to someone else for a premium. This chapter explains the basics only: it is not advice about specific products. Compare options carefully and read the policy documents.

Type	Who may need it	Plain-language idea
Health insurance	Almost everyone	Pays for covered hospital costs. Do not rely only on employer cover if it ends when you leave the job.
Term life insurance	People with dependents or loans others would inherit	Pays a sum to nominees if you die during the term. No maturity benefit, so the premium is lower.
Personal accident / disability	People whose income depends on working	Covers some accident-related costs or income loss. Check exclusions.
Vehicle and home	Owners	Legal and practical protection for assets.

Questions to ask before buying any policy

- What exactly is covered, and what is excluded?
- Are there waiting periods or sub-limits?
- Is the insurer regulated by IRDAI, and what is its claim-settlement record?
- Is this pure protection, or is it bundled with an investment? (Compare them separately.)
- Can I afford the premium for the whole policy term without stress?

WATCH OUT

Be careful when someone sells insurance as a “guaranteed investment” or “save tax and earn returns”. Ask for the full cost, the charges, the surrender terms and the benefit illustration in writing. If it is complicated, ask a registered adviser who is not paid commission on the sale.

TRY THIS

Write down: your health cover (self/family), any term cover, and when each premium is due. Add the annual amounts to your irregular-expense calendar.

Irregular Expenses: The Predictable Surprises

Diwali is not a surprise. It happens every year.

Many “unexpected” expenses are not unexpected at all. They are just irregular. Insurance premiums, school fees, festivals, weddings, annual subscriptions, vehicle service, property tax. When they arrive, they land on a month that was never designed to carry them, and a credit card catches the fall.

The sinking-fund method

KEY IDEA

Annual cost ÷ 12 = monthly amount to set aside.

Irregular expense	Annual cost	Set aside monthly
Festival spending and gifts	₹18,000	₹1,500
Health insurance premium	₹12,000	₹1,000
Vehicle service and insurance	₹9,000	₹750
Annual subscriptions	₹6,000	₹500
Travel home during holidays	₹12,000	₹1,000
Total	₹57,000	₹4,750

(Fictional example.) If that total looks large, it is the number you were already paying. You were just paying it as a shock instead of in portions.

WORKSHEET | My Irregular-Expense Calendar

Expense	Month due	Annual cost	Monthly set-aside

PART IV

Start Building Wealth

Goals first. Products later.

Goals Before Products

“Which mutual fund?” is question seven. Question one is “money for what?”

A savings plan with no goal is a plan to be talked out of saving. Investments chosen before goals are usually chosen by whoever last convinced you.

Name your three goals

Time horizon	Example goals	What matters most
Short (under 3 years)	Safety buffer, a phone, a trip, a certification	Safety and availability
Medium (3 to 7 years)	A wedding, a down payment, a vehicle, further study	Balance of safety and growth
Long (7+ years)	Retirement, a child's education, a home	Time, patience and discipline

WORKSHEET | My Three Goals

Goal	Target amount	Needed by (date)	Months left	Monthly needed

Monthly needed = target amount ÷ months left (before any growth, which you should not count on). Example: ₹60,000 for a laptop in 12 months = ₹5,000 a month.

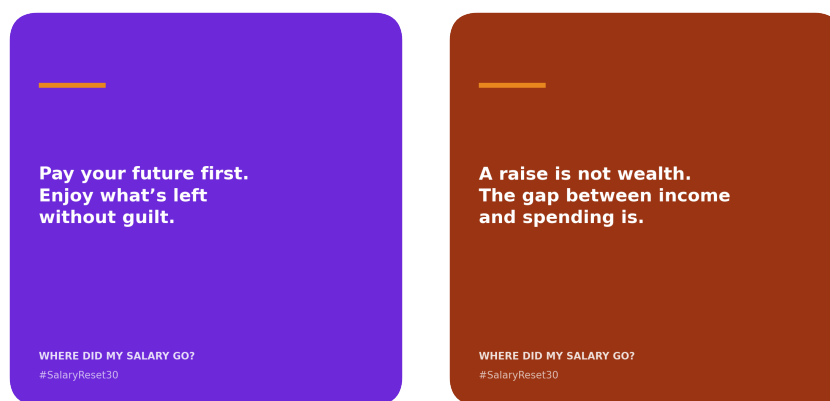
KEY IDEA

The shorter the goal, the less risk the money should take. Money needed in 12 months should not depend on a market going up in 12 months.

REAL LIFE | Goal-less saving

Problem: “I want to save, but I have no idea for what.”

The fix: pick one goal that you can picture in 12 months (a laptop, a trip home, a certification) and a second you can picture in 5 years. Name them, price them, divide by months left. A named goal is far harder to raid than a vague “savings” balance.



CHAPTER 17

Saving vs Investing

Two different tools for two different jobs.

	Saving	Investing
Main purpose	Safety, short-term goals, emergencies	Growing money over longer periods
Risk of loss	Low	Higher; values can fall, sometimes for years
Access	Quick	Varies; may involve charges or timing risk
Time horizon	Days to a few years	Typically several years or more
Right for	Safety buffer, near-term goals	Long-term goals, once the foundation exists

The order that works

Cash flow → safety buffer → expensive debt → goals → suitable investments.

Investing before your cash flow is stable usually leads to selling the investment at a bad moment to cover a short-term need. A buffer is not the enemy of investing. It is the thing that lets you stay invested.

WATCH OUT

Do not invest money you will need soon. Do not invest borrowed money. And never put your emergency fund into anything whose value can fall.

REAL LIFE | Peer pressure

Problem: “My friends say stop saving and put everything in the market.”

Reply: “I keep money I need within a few years in safe places, and money for long-term goals in things that can grow, after my buffer is built.” Different jobs, different tools.

TRY THIS

Label every rupee you have saved with a job: *safety*, *goal within 3 years*, or *long-term*. Anything unlabelled is a decision waiting to be made.



Safety first: the buffer ladder from Chapter 12.

CHAPTER 18

Compounding: Patience Made Visible

Growth that earns more growth, if you give it time.

Compounding means that returns can themselves earn returns. It rewards starting early and staying put. Here is a **purely hypothetical** illustration to show the mechanism:

Time	You put in (₹2,000/month)	Illustrative value at 8% a year
5 years	₹1,20,000	₹1,46,954
10 years	₹2,40,000	₹3,65,892
20 years	₹4,80,000	₹11,78,041
30 years	₹7,20,000	₹29,80,719

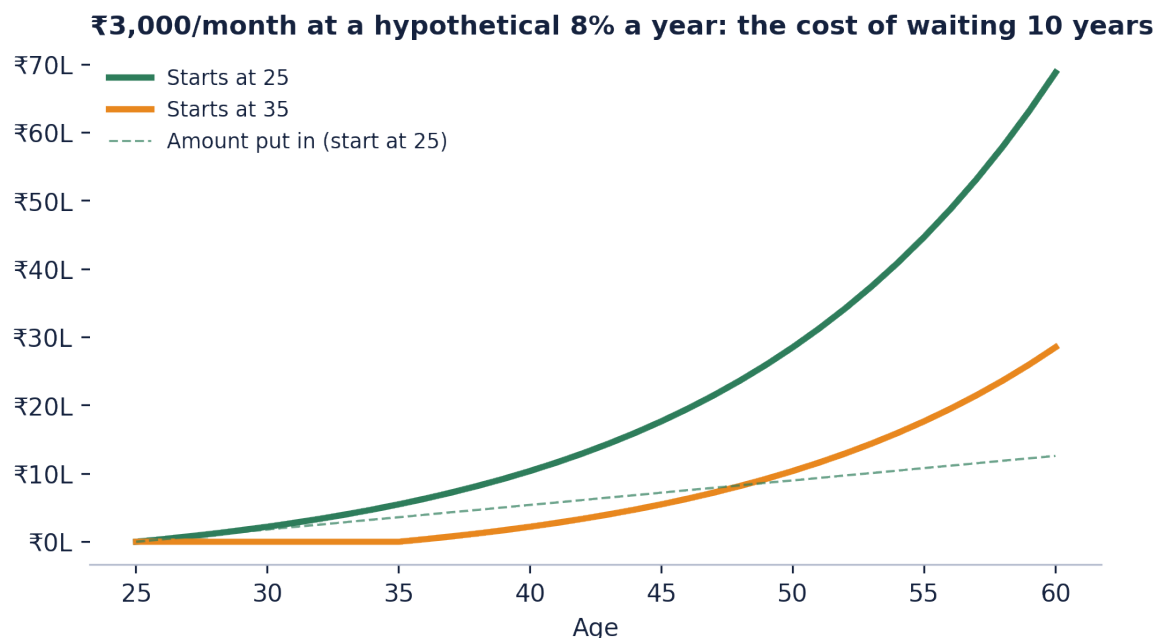
WATCH OUT

This is not a projection or a promise. The 8% is an assumption chosen to demonstrate arithmetic. Real returns vary year to year and can be negative. Different products have different risks and costs. Taxes and charges reduce results.

The lesson is the shape of the curve: **time does more of the work than the amount.**

What this means for you

- Starting with a small amount is better than waiting for a large one.
- Interrupting (withdrawing, stopping) is the most common way to lose the benefit.
- Compounding works against you too: unpaid credit-card interest compounds on *you*.



Hypothetical illustration at an assumed 8% a year, not a forecast.

ORIGINAL METRIC | Cost of Delay

Cost of Delay. Same ₹3,000 a month, same assumed 8%, to age 60:

Start at 25: **₹68,81,647** (you put in ₹12,60,000).

Start at 35: **₹28,53,079** (you put in ₹9,00,000).

Waiting ten years adds ₹3,60,000 less in contributions but costs about **₹40,28,568** in this illustration. The first years are the most valuable ones.

This is arithmetic about time, not a prediction. Real returns are uneven and can be negative.

KEY IDEA

Rule of 72: divide 72 by an assumed yearly growth rate to estimate years to double. At 6%: about 12 years. At 8%: about 9 years. At 12%: about 6 years. The same rule works against you on debt: at an assumed 36% a year, a balance doubles in about 2 years if left unpaid.

CHAPTER 19

Inflation: The Slow Leak

Money in a drawer is safe from thieves and not from time.

Inflation means prices rise over time, so each rupee buys a little less. At a hypothetical 6% annual rate:

After	What ₹100 of goods costs today	What ₹100 of cash buys (in today's terms)
5 years	₹100	₹75
10 years	₹100	₹56
20 years	₹100	₹31

(Illustrative rate, not a forecast.) This is why long-term goals usually need money that can grow, and why short-term goals still need safety first. It is a balancing act, not a rule.

INDIA DATA

India's official inflation data is published regularly by MoSPI (CPI), and the RBI discusses inflation in its policy statements. Check those sources for current rates rather than relying on any number printed in a book.

WORKSHEET | Inflation-Proof My Goal

Line	My number
Goal cost today	
Years until I need it	
Assumed inflation rate (my estimate)	
Cost then = today $\times (1 + \text{rate})^{\text{years}}$	

What ₹100 of cash buys, if prices rise 6% a year (illustrative)



Cash loses purchasing power quietly, which is why long-term goals need a plan.

REAL LIFE | “Cash is safe”

Problem: “I keep all my savings in cash at home. It’s safe.”

The fix: keep your safety buffer in a safe, accessible bank account, and think about longer-term goals separately: they need a plan that keeps pace with rising prices. Which products suit you depends on your goals, time horizon and risk comfort. Ask a SEBI-registered adviser before you decide.

You Don't Need to Become a Stock Market Expert

You need to know enough not to be fooled.

INDIA DATA | SEBI Investor Survey 2025

SEBI's Investor Survey 2025 reported that a majority of Indian households were aware of at least one securities-market product, yet actual household participation was far lower, around one in ten. It also found most households fell in the low-risk-tolerance category.

What it means: awareness is not the same as participation or understanding. *What it does not mean:* that low risk tolerance is “wrong” or that everyone should invest in markets. See the Sources appendix.

Four building blocks

Block	Plain idea	Typical role
Savings and deposits	Lend to a bank; principal is relatively safe	Safety buffer, near goals
Debt instruments	Lend to governments or companies for a fixed term	Stability, medium goals
Equity	Own part of a business; value can swing widely	Long-term growth, with patience
Gold and others	Hold value differently from other assets	Diversification for some people

Five ideas to understand before buying anything

- **Risk:** the chance of losing money or earning less than expected.
- **Liquidity:** how quickly you can get cash out without a loss.
- **Time horizon:** how long until you need the money.
- **Diversification:** not putting everything in one place.
- **Costs:** fees, charges and taxes that reduce what you keep.

A sensible sequence

- Complete KYC and open accounts only with SEBI-registered intermediaries or regulated platforms.
- Start with what you understand. If you cannot explain it to a friend, do not buy it yet.
- Choose a small, regular amount you can continue in difficult years.
- Read the official scheme documents for any mutual fund, including risk, costs and exit terms.

- Review once or twice a year, not daily.

KEY IDEA

This book deliberately does not recommend any fund, stock or scheme. A recommendation that ignores your goals, timeline and risk comfort is just an advertisement. Use official investor-education resources from SEBI and AMFI, and consider a SEBI-registered investment adviser for personalised guidance.

REAL LIFE | Information overload

Problem: “I want to start investing but every video says something different.”

The fix: go to the sources that are not selling you anything: regulator investor-education pages and official scheme documents. Write down three things before you invest: the goal, the time horizon and the worst fall you could live with. If you cannot answer all three, you are not ready to buy yet, and that is fine.

You don't need a bigger salary first.
You need to see the salary
you already have.

WHERE DID MY SALARY GO?
#SalaryReset30

The real enemy isn't your ₹50 coffee
It's the 40 transactions
you forgot about.

WHERE DID MY SALARY GO?
#SalaryReset30

Avoiding Scams and Bad Advice

The best return you will ever get is the loss you did not take.

Fraud thrives where people are in a hurry, in need, or embarrassed to ask questions. Learn the patterns, because the details change but the patterns do not.

Twelve red flags

- “Guaranteed returns” or returns that are far above anything normal
- Pressure to decide today, or “limited slots”
- Requests for an OTP, PIN, CVV, screen sharing or remote-access app
- Unsolicited calls, messages or group invites offering stock tips
- Anyone asking you to pay money first to “unlock” a bigger payout
- Unregistered advisers, “mentors” and finance influencers selling secret strategies
- Schemes that pay you for recruiting others
- Instant-loan apps that ask for contacts and gallery access
- Fake customer-care numbers found through search results
- Screenshots of profits as proof
- “Insider” tips and operator calls
- Complex products you cannot explain in two sentences

What to do

- Verify registration of any adviser or intermediary on the regulator’s official website (for example SEBI’s intermediary search).
- Never share OTPs, PINs or passwords. Banks and regulators will not ask for them.
- If you have been defrauded online, act quickly: contact your bank to freeze transactions, and report on the national cybercrime portal or helpline (verify the current helpline number on the official government site).
- Complain through official channels, such as the regulator’s grievance system, the bank’s ombudsman scheme or consumer forums.

TRY THIS

Write a three-line personal rule and keep it in your phone notes: (1) I never share an OTP. (2) I never invest in anything I cannot explain. (3) I never decide a money question on a call.

REAL LIFE | The OTP call

Scenario: a message says, “Your account will be blocked. Share the OTP to verify.”

What to do: do not reply or click. Banks do not ask for OTPs or PINs. Call the number printed on the back of your card or on the bank’s official website, not a number from the message. If money has already moved, call your bank at once and report it through the official cybercrime channels.

REAL LIFE | The tips group

Scenario: a group invite promises daily profits on tips from a “professor”.

What to do: leave the group. Real advisers are registered and do not DM you. Screenshots of profits prove nothing.



Remember the order: allocate and protect before you spend or invest.

PART V

Lessons From Wealthy People

Examples, not authorities. Research first, famous names second.

CHAPTER 22

What Can We Actually Learn From Wealthy People?

Not “the secret habits of billionaires”. Something more useful and more honest.

Famous names sell books, but they can mislead. A billionaire’s habit is not a rule, and their situation is nothing like yours. So this part follows a strict hierarchy:

Step	Example
Research	Automatic mechanisms can influence saving behaviour.
Principle	Reduce reliance on willpower.
Application	Automate an appropriate transfer after salary credit.
Example	A well-known investor emphasises saving, early financial education and long-term thinking.

WATCH OUT

The statements below are paraphrased from public sources. Wording, context and circumstances change over time. Check the original sources listed in the appendix before quoting anyone in your own work.

CHAPTER 23

Warren Buffett: Think Long Term

WEALTH LESSON | Buffett | patience and habits

Start early and keep learning. At Berkshire Hathaway annual meetings, Buffett has repeatedly spoken about the value of learning about money early and building the habit of saving and curiosity.

Lesson for you: start financial habits before you feel “rich enough”. Save something consistently *before* you raise your lifestyle.

WEALTH LESSON | Buffett | status vs substance

Do not confuse spending with status. Buffett is widely documented as living modestly relative to his wealth and has contrasted long-term, patient shareholders with conspicuous consumption.

Lesson for you: wealth and visible consumption are not the same thing. Before an expensive purchase, ask: “*Do I want this, or do I want people to see this?*”

WEALTH LESSON | Buffett | borrowing

Be careful with expensive debt. Buffett has publicly cautioned about the cost of high-interest credit-card borrowing.

Lesson for you: Red debt first. No investment pitch reliably beats avoiding a very high interest rate.

CHAPTER 24

Bill Gates: Allocate Intentionally

WEALTH LESSON | Gates | purposeful money

Gates' own writing describes a philosophy built on setting goals, measuring results, directing resources where they can have impact, and thinking about risk. He has also publicly said he intends to give away virtually all of his wealth through the Gates Foundation over time.

Lesson for you, not “give away your money like Bill Gates”, but: money should be connected to priorities. Ask: *“What do I actually want my money to accomplish?”*

Your version is smaller and just as valid: your three goals from Chapter 16 are your “mission statement”. Measure progress monthly, as the Salary Reset does.

CHAPTER 25

Elon Musk: Consumption vs Wealth Creation

WEALTH LESSON | Musk | spending vs ownership

In a 2022 interview, Musk said that at that time he did not own a home and described his personal consumption as relatively low (with a private jet as a notable exception). His wealth is largely tied to company ownership rather than cash he spends.

Lesson for you: high net worth does not require maximising visible consumption. Separate *things that improve your life* from *things that signal your status*.

WATCH OUT

Do not turn this into “don’t own a house like Musk”. That would be absurd advice for most people. The point is about the distinction between consumption and asset ownership, not about copying a lifestyle.

CHAPTER 26

Other Principles That Appear Again and Again

Beyond any single name, a handful of ideas appear in serious personal-finance literature and in the documented habits of many long-term savers:

Principle	Plain meaning
Spend less than you earn	The gap creates all other options
Avoid ruinous debt	Interest compounds against you
Be patient	Time in the market often matters more than timing
Keep learning	Knowledge protects you from scams and sales pitches
Protect the downside	Safety buffer and insurance first, returns later
Keep costs low	What you do not pay stays with you

CHAPTER 27

What Not to Copy

- **Concentrated bets.** Founders hold wealth in one company. For most people, that is dangerous.
- **Borrowing to invest.** Leverage can magnify losses as well as gains.
- **Survivorship bias.** You hear about the winners, not the thousands who did the same and failed.
- **Billionaire timelines.** Their resources, tax situations and access are not yours.
- **Quotes without context.** A one-line quote can reverse its meaning when separated from its source.

KEY IDEA

Use famous people to *illustrate* a principle, never to *prove* it. The proof is in research and in your own numbers.

PART VI

Your Reset

Four fictional case studies, your questions answered, and a 30-day plan.

CHAPTER 28

Case Study: ₹20,000 Salary

Rahul, 24, a Tier-2 city. (Fictional composite.)

Rahul supports his family, has no emergency fund, and says, “There is nothing left to save.”

Before	Monthly
Family contribution	₹5,000
Rent	₹4,000
Food	₹3,000
Travel	₹2,000
Shopping / eating out	₹2,000
Subscriptions / misc	₹1,000
Total tracked	₹17,000
Untracked (the autopsy finding)	₹3,000

The autopsy revealed ₹3,000 of small, forgotten spending, about 15% of salary. Rahul did not need a raise to find money. He needed to see it.

After: five buckets	Monthly
Must Live (rent, food, travel)	₹9,000
Must Pay (family support, planned)	₹5,000
Must Protect (₹1,500 buffer + ₹1,500 irregular)	₹3,000
Must Build (small recurring deposit)	₹500
Can Enjoy (spending wallet)	₹2,500
Total	₹20,000

KEY IDEA

Rahul’s Level 1 safety buffer (₹5,000) takes about 4 months at ₹1,500 a month. Then his goal is Level 2. Small, steady, visible.

Case Study: ₹30,000 Salary

Priya, 27, Bengaluru. (Fictional composite.)

“I earn more than I did two years ago, but I’m still broke.” Priya’s autopsy is in Chapter 2. Her income went up. Her spending went up faster, and every new rupee found a lifestyle expense.

Bucket	Before (approx.)	After
Must Live (rent, groceries, travel)	₹14,500	₹14,500
Must Pay (EMI, family)	₹5,500	₹5,500
Delivery, subscriptions, shopping, misc, small UPI, outings and gifts	₹10,000	—
Must Protect (₹2,500 buffer + ₹2,000 irregular)	₹0	₹4,500
Must Build	₹0	₹2,000
Can Enjoy	(inside the ₹10,000 above)	₹3,500
Total	₹30,000	₹30,000

She did not cut her life in half. She reduced the formerly unplanned ₹10,000 to a planned ₹3,500 of enjoyment, redirecting ₹4,500 (about 15% of salary) into safety and future. By Priya’s account, the hardest part was cancelling subscriptions. The easiest was the salary-day transfer, because it only needed to be set up once.

BEHAVIOUR

Priya’s “enjoy” budget is not smaller shame. It is a *permission slip*. When money is assigned to enjoyment, guilt tends to fade.

Case Study: ₹50,000 Salary

Amit, 30. Two EMIs, a credit-card balance, parents. (Fictional composite.)

Before	Monthly
Rent	₹12,000
Groceries	₹5,000
Transport	₹3,000
Utilities	₹2,000
Personal-loan EMI	₹6,000
Two-wheeler EMI	₹3,000
Credit-card payment	₹3,000
Parents	₹5,000
Eating out	₹4,000
Shopping	₹3,000
Entertainment / subscriptions	₹1,500
Miscellaneous	₹2,500
Total	₹50,000

Debt payments: ₹12,000 ÷ ₹50,000 = **24%** EMI Burden. No emergency reserve. Each surprise goes on the card. This is how Red debt keeps renewing.

Debt-first or savings-first?

A common dilemma. The logic Amit used:

- **Step 1: a small safety starter first.** Without even ₹5,000 in the bank, the next surprise goes on the card and undoes his repayments.
- **Step 2: attack the Red debt.** The credit-card balance carries the highest cost, so extra repayment goes there, while minimums continue on the other loans.
- **Step 3: once the card is clear,** redirect that payment to the next-costliest loan or to the safety buffer, then to goals.

Lifestyle cut	Before	After	Freed
Eating out	₹4,000	₹2,000	₹2,000
Shopping	₹3,000	₹1,500	₹1,500
Entertainment / subscriptions	₹1,500	₹1,000	₹500
Miscellaneous	₹2,500	₹1,500	₹1,000

Lifestyle cut	Before	After	Freed
Total freed each month			₹5,000

For the first two months: ₹2,500 a month to the safety starter (reaching ₹5,000) and ₹2,500 as extra payment on the card. After that, the full ₹5,000 goes to the card until it is cleared. Amit also stopped using the card for anything he could not repay in full that month.

WATCH OUT

Amit's plan is an example. The right order depends on interest rates, the size of balances, loan terms and your job security. Check your own documents.

CHAPTER 31

Case Study: ₹1,00,000 Salary

"I earn well. Why am I still not building wealth?" (Fictional composite.)

This case exists so that the book does not sound like it is only for people on tight incomes. A high salary does not remove the problem. It changes its shape.

Before	Monthly
Housing	₹25,000
Food and utilities	₹10,000
Lifestyle (eating out, entertainment)	₹15,000
Family support	₹15,000
EMI	₹10,000
Travel and shopping	₹10,000
Miscellaneous	₹10,000
Investments	₹5,000
Total	₹1,00,000

Savings rate: $₹5,000 \div ₹1,00,000 = 5\%$. A six-figure salary, and a five-per-cent gap. The problem is not income. **It is allocation.**

After: five buckets	Monthly
Must Live (housing + food/utilities)	₹35,000
Must Pay (family + EMI)	₹25,000
Must Protect (₹8,000 buffer + ₹5,000 irregular)	₹13,000
Must Build (goals and investments)	₹17,000
Can Enjoy	₹10,000
Total	₹1,00,000

The old lifestyle, travel and miscellaneous lines (₹35,000) became ₹15,000 of planned Enjoy and irregular spending. The freed ₹20,000 went to Protect and Build, moving the savings rate from 5% to **17%** on the Build line alone, and 30% counting the safety buffer.

CHAPTER 32

What If...? Your Questions Answered

The questions people actually type into Google and Reddit.

What if my salary is only ₹15,000?

Start with the autopsy and a ₹500 to ₹1,000 monthly transfer to the Level 1 safety buffer. The habit matters more than the amount. Look for your first Leak Score and one expense to cut.

What if I support my parents?

Budget it in Bucket 2 as a planned amount, with a small reserve for requests (Chapter 11).

What if I have an EMI?

Calculate your EMI Burden. Keep paying on time, avoid new ones, and treat costly ones as Red or Yellow (Chapter 10).

What if I have credit-card debt?

Stop adding to it. Build a small starter buffer, then pay it down aggressively. Check the rate on your statement.

What if I live in Mumbai or Bengaluru?

Housing will dominate Must Live. Spend your effort on negotiating rent, commute choices and the lifestyle bucket. Percentages will differ from small-city peers, and that is fine.

What if I live in a smaller city?

Costs are lower but so can be options. The same five buckets work; only the numbers differ.

What if my income changes every month?

Plan on your **lowest typical month** for Must Live and Must Pay. When a month is better, split the extra using fixed rules: for example, half to safety/goals, the rest to flexibility. Build a larger buffer.

What if I'm self-employed?

Separate business and personal accounts. Pay yourself a fixed "salary" from the business, and set aside money for taxes and irregular income. Ask a qualified tax professional about obligations.

What if my spouse also earns?

Decide whether to pool or split. Many couples use three accounts: yours, mine, ours. Hold a monthly money meeting.

What if I have children?

Add child-related costs and education goals to the plan. Health and term cover matter more. Review annually.

What if I already have investments?

Great. Check that your safety buffer and Red debt are handled first, and that each investment has a goal.

What if I'm starting from zero?

Begin with Day 1 of the 30-Day Reset. Zero is a position, not a verdict.

CHAPTER 33

“What Would I Do With...?”

Find the situation closest to yours. These are sample splits, not instructions.

Situation	Live	Pay	Protect	Build	Enjoy	Total
I take home ₹20,000 and have no big commitments	₹10,000	₹1,000	₹3,500	₹1,500	₹4,000	₹20,000
₹30,000, living with parents	₹6,000	₹7,000	₹6,000	₹6,000	₹5,000	₹30,000
₹40,000, paying ₹10,000 rent	₹22,000	₹4,000	₹5,000	₹4,000	₹5,000	₹40,000
₹50,000 with ₹3 lakh debt (Must Pay includes extra debt repayment)	₹20,000	₹22,000	₹3,000	₹1,000	₹4,000	₹50,000
₹80,000 but zero savings	₹32,000	₹8,000	₹12,000	₹16,000	₹12,000	₹80,000
₹1,00,000 while supporting my family	₹34,000	₹28,000	₹12,000	₹14,000	₹12,000	₹1,00,000

What stays the same in every row: **Protect gets funded first**, Enjoy is never zero, and every rupee has an assignment. What changes: the proportions, which depend on your commitments.

CHAPTER 34

The 30-Day Salary Reset

Ten blocks. Ten to thirty minutes a day. One complete money map at the end.

Days	Task	Chapter
1-3	Collect statements: bank, UPI, cards, loans, subscriptions	2
4-7	Categorise last month's spending; calculate your Leak Score	2
8-10	Find recurring leaks; do the 7-Day UPI Audit	3, 4
11-13	Cancel or reduce unnecessary expenses and subscriptions	9
14-16	Create your five buckets with real numbers	7
17-19	Audit debt: EMI Burden, Red/Yellow/Green, repayment order	10
20-21	Plan your safety buffer and irregular-expense fund	12, 14
22-24	Define three financial goals (short, medium, long)	16
25-27	Automate the appropriate transfers; check insurance	8, 13
28-30	Design next month's money system; schedule your monthly review	34

Your 30-day tracker

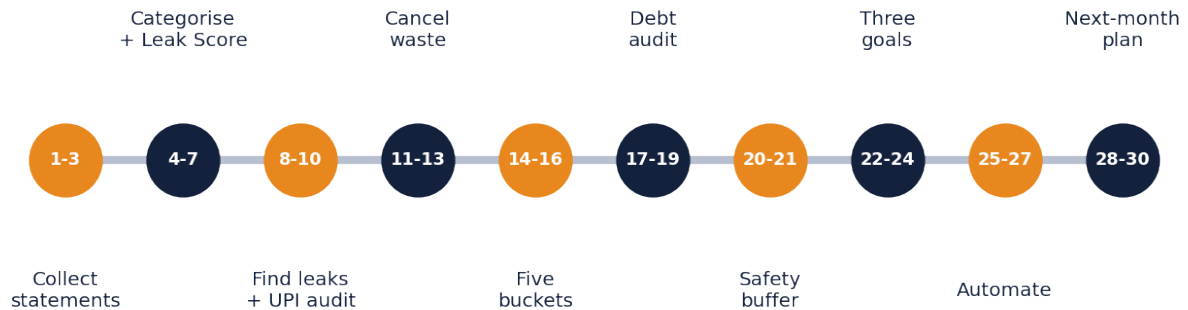
WORKSHEET | Tick as you go

Block	Days	Started	Finished	Biggest discovery
Collect statements				
Categorise				
Find leaks				
Cut leaks				
Buckets				
Debt audit				
Safety buffer				
Goals				
Automate				
Next-month plan				

KEY IDEA

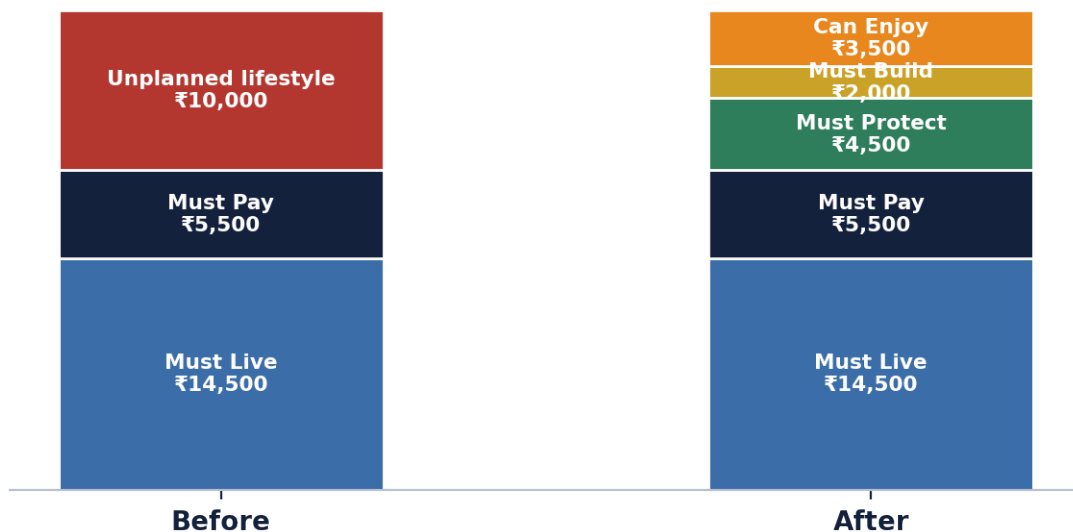
Do not aim for perfection. A reset done at 70% on time is worth far more than a perfect one that never starts.

DAYS



Your 30 days on one line.

Priya's ₹30,000: same income, new assignment



What the finished plan looks like for Priya (fictional).

SHARE THIS

Post your Day-1 number and your Day-30 number. People love a before and after, and it keeps you accountable.

PART VII

Playbooks and Bonus Material

*Real-life problems and fixes, word-for-word scripts, documented
millionaire patterns, and a creator kit.*

BONUS 1

Twelve Real-Life Money Problems, and Real Fixes

Find yours. Each one follows the same pattern: situation, why it happens, what to do this week.

1. “My salary is delayed and rent is due.”

Why it happens: No buffer, and bills lined up with salary day.

The fix this week: Message the landlord early and honestly, propose a date. Use your Level 1 buffer, not a loan app. After this, build toward the one-month-ahead goal.

2. “Festival season ate my savings.”

Why it happens: It is predictable, but was not budgeted.

The fix this week: Create a festival line in the irregular-expense calendar (annual cost ÷ 12). Set a gift cap per person and buy early instead of at peak prices.

3. “A friend wants me to split everything equally, but I earn less.”

Why it happens: Social pressure outweighs your budget.

The fix this week: Suggest cheaper plans in advance, or say: “I’m in, but my budget for this is ₹____. Can we pick a place within it?” Good friends adjust. If they do not, skip the occasional outing.

4. “I got a ‘pre-approved’ loan offer on my phone.”

Why it happens: Offers are designed to feel like free money.

The fix this week: Treat it as a product, not a gift. Ask for the full cost: rate, fees, total repayment. If you did not need the money before the notification, you do not need it after.

5. “Everyone at work is buying a new phone and I feel left behind.”

Why it happens: Social comparison.

The fix this week: Use the status question (“Do I want this or do I want people to see this?”) and Hourly Life Cost. If you still want it, plan it as a goal and buy it with saved money.

6. “I have three EMIs and no idea what I owe.”

Why it happens: Debt without a map.

The fix this week: Build the Debt Map worksheet in Chapter 10. Write each rate. Pay the Red one first and keep minimums on the rest.

7. “My parents don’t understand budgeting.”

Why it happens: Different money culture and different life stage.

The fix this week: Do not lecture. Show a single page: planned family support, the reserve, and what the budget protects them from. Invite their input on festivals and medical needs.

8. “I started a SIP and stopped after three months.”

Why it happens: The amount was too high for your cash flow, or the goal was unclear.

The fix this week: Restart with an amount you can sustain even in a tight month. Link it to a named goal. Check the automatic date is a few days after salary.

9. “A finfluencer said this scheme doubles money in a year.”

Why it happens: Promises of fixed high returns are a classic red flag.

The fix this week: Check registration on the official regulator site. Never invest in anything you cannot explain. Wait 72 hours.

10. “I’m self-employed and some months I earn nothing.”

Why it happens: Irregular income, constant expenses.

The fix this week: Budget from your lowest typical month. Hold a larger buffer (many people aim for more months than salaried workers). Pay yourself a fixed monthly amount from the business account.

11. “I lost money on a stock tip.”

Why it happens: Tips are not plans.

The fix this week: Do not chase the loss. Write down what you learned. Pause new investing until your goals, buffer and rules are written. Consider educational resources from SEBI and a registered adviser.

12. “I’m 35, with nothing saved. Is it too late?”

Why it happens: Comparison with an imaginary version of you.

The fix this week: No. Time matters, but the best first step is the same: autopsy, buffer, Red debt, then a small automatic transfer. Increase it every raise. The cost-of-delay table is a reason to start, not a reason to give up.

BONUS 2

What to Say: Scripts for Awkward Money Moments

Most money mistakes happen in conversations. Have the words ready.

REAL LIFE | Asking for a raise

"Over the last ___ months I took on ___ and delivered ___. I'd like to discuss revising my compensation. Based on my role and market information, I'm looking at ___. Can we find time this week?" *Bring a short list of results, not a list of your expenses.*

REAL LIFE | Lender or credit-card company

"I want to reduce my repayment cost. Please tell me my current interest rate, any fees, and whether I can convert this balance to a fixed EMI or restructure it. Please send the terms in writing."

REAL LIFE | Declining an expensive group plan

"That sounds fun, but it's outside my budget this month. How about we do ___ instead?"

REAL LIFE | Starting a money talk with a partner

"I'm trying to get clearer on our finances. Can we spend ten minutes on Sunday looking at what comes in, what goes out, and one goal we both want?"

REAL LIFE | Politely refusing a sales pitch

"Thank you. I don't decide financial products on the spot. Please email me the full documents, costs, and your registration number, and I'll review them."

REAL LIFE | When someone insists you invest in their "opportunity"

"I don't invest in anything I can't explain or verify. If it's legitimate, it will still be there after I've checked."

REAL LIFE | Asking parents about shared expenses

"I want to support the household reliably. Can we agree on a monthly amount, plus a separate way to handle medical or festival costs?"

BONUS 3

What Self-Made Millionaires Actually Do

The truth is less glamorous than the internet suggests, and more usable.

WATCH OUT

There is no secret that rich people hide. Anyone selling “millionaire secrets” is selling packaging. What follows are **documented patterns** and **maths**. Sources are in Appendix B, and you should read the originals.

Pattern 1: they spend less than the average person with the same income

In *The Millionaire Next Door* (1996), researchers Thomas Stanley and William Danko studied affluent US households and described “prodigious accumulators of wealth”: people whose net worth was much higher than their income would predict, largely because they lived below their means, planned their spending and avoided status purchases. Many ordinary-looking households held more wealth than flashier, higher-earning ones. *Caveat*: US data from a particular period, so the lesson is the pattern, not the exact numbers.

Pattern 2: most of the money is made by time, late in the story

Warren Buffett is widely reported to have built the large majority of his wealth after his fiftieth birthday, a picture of long compounding more than a single clever trade. He is also widely documented as still living in the Omaha house he bought in 1958. Read these as examples of patience and modest consumption, not as instructions.

Pattern 3: they own things that produce, not things that signal

Founders such as Sam Walton have been widely reported to have driven an old pickup truck and kept personal spending modest while their wealth sat in the business. The principle: **separate what you consume from what you own**, and grow the second.

The Millionaire Math: three levers

Lever	What it means	Your move this year
Income	What you bring in	Learn a skill that raises pay; negotiate; build a side income
Gap	Income minus spending	Leak Score, Raise Capture Rate, five buckets

Lever	What it means	Your move this year		
Time	How long money can work	Start a small automatic amount now, then grow it		
Monthly amount	10 years	20 years	30 years	
₹2,000	₹3,65,892	₹11,78,041	₹29,80,719	
₹5,000	₹9,14,730	₹29,45,102	₹74,51,797	
₹10,000	₹18,29,460	₹58,90,204	₹1,49,03,594	

Hypothetical, at an assumed 8% a year, before tax and costs; not a forecast. Notice that the biggest numbers come from **time**, not from the biggest monthly amount.

Ten questions worth borrowing

- Is this an asset, an experience, or a status signal?
- Will I still want this in 30 days?
- How many hours of my life does it cost?
- What is the annual cost, not the monthly one?
- Does this bring me closer to one of my three goals?
- What is the cost if I am wrong?
- Who benefits if I say yes?
- Can I explain it to a friend in two sentences?
- What would I do with this money if I did not spend it here?
- Will future me thank me?

SHARE THIS

"The secret of wealthy people isn't a secret. It's a boring gap between income and spending, kept for a long time."

BONUS 4

The Creator Kit: Hooks, Scripts and a 30-Day Content Plan

For creators, educators and coaches who want to share this material with their audience, responsibly.

Why this book is easy to turn into content

Every chapter ends in something your audience can *do* and *share*: a number (Leak Score, EMI Burden, Salary Half-Life, Raise Capture Rate, Hourly Life Cost) and a feeling (“where did it go?”). Numbers invite comparison, and comparison drives comments.

Share-ready cards



Transparent-background PNG files for these cards and the charts are supplied with the book.

Thirty hooks (first lines)

Hooks 1-15

1. Your salary isn't disappearing. You're spending it before giving it a job.

Hooks 16-30

16. Pay your future first. Spend what's left, guilt-free.

Hooks 1-15	Hooks 16-30
2. ₹199 × 12 is not ₹199.	17. The 24-hour rule that saves more than coupons.
3. What is your Salary Half-Life? Mine was day 5.	18. Three red flags in every influencer pitch.
4. Where did the first ₹10,000 of your ₹50,000 go?	19. What “guaranteed returns” really means.
5. A raise that makes you poorer: the Raise Capture Rate.	20. Cost of Delay: why 35 is not too late.
6. That phone costs you 173 hours of work.	21. The 7-Day UPI Audit: try it with me.
7. The 40 UPI payments you forgot you made.	22. Why I split my salary into five buckets.
8. Why 50/30/20 doesn't work for most Indian households.	23. The festival expense that isn't a surprise.
9. The minimum payment is not a plan.	24. The savings account for goals, not for investing.
10. Your emergency fund isn't “six months”. It's Level 1.	25. How to say no to a family loan request, kindly.
11. One question to ask before every purchase.	26. The one setting that stops impulse orders.
12. The subscription audit that found ₹12,000.	27. Salary day routine: what I do in 10 minutes.
13. Why your family budget needs a reserve line.	28. Why the rich aren't hiding a secret.
14. Lifestyle inflation in one table.	29. A month of tracking: what surprised me.
15. Do you know your EMI Burden?	30. Day 30: my money map is done.

Five carousel outlines (7 slides each)

Carousel	Slide-by-slide
Where did my salary go?	1 Hook: ₹30,000 gone by the 24th. 2 The five destinations. 3 The donut. 4 Salary Half-Life. 5 The fix: buckets. 6 Salary-day rule. 7 CTA: calculate your half-life.
The ₹100 problem	1 Hook. 2 Six small spends. 3 Multiply by 20. 4 $4 \times 12 = ₹36,000$. 5 Annualise everything. 6 One subscription to cancel. 7 CTA: share your number.
Lifestyle inflation	1 Hook: raise, still broke. 2 The phone table. 3 The two charts. 4 Raise Capture Rate. 5 The raise rule. 6 Example A vs B. 7 CTA: your capture rate.
EMI Burden	1 Hook. 2 Formula. 3 The ₹40,000 example. 4 Red, Yellow, Green. 5 The minimum trap. 6 Repayment order. 7 CTA: calculate yours.
30-day Salary Reset	1 Hook. 2 The roadmap. 3 Days 1-7. 4 Days 8-16. 5 Days 17-24. 6 Days 25-30. 7 CTA: start #SalaryReset30.

Five 30-second reel scripts

Reel	Script outline
Half-life	Hook (0-3s): “Half my salary is gone by day 5.” Middle: show rent, family, EMI landing. Turn: “That’s my Salary Half-Life.” CTA: “Find yours; comment the day.”

Reel	Script outline
₹499	Hook: "This ₹499 app costs ₹5,988." Middle: annualise three subscriptions. CTA: "Cancel one today."
Phone hours	Hook: "This phone cost me 173 hours." Middle: Hourly Life Cost formula. CTA: "Your phone, in hours?"
UPI audit	Hook: "I tracked 7 days of UPI. Here's the damage." Middle: totals, count, reducible amount. CTA: "Do the audit with me."
Raise rate	Hook: "My raise made me poorer." Middle: Example A vs B. CTA: "What's your capture rate?"

A four-week content calendar

Week	Theme	Posts
1	See: statements, autopsy, Leak Score	Carousel (autopsy), Reel (half-life), Story poll (guess your leak)
2	Fix: leaks, UPI audit, subscriptions	Reel (annualise), Carousel (₹100 problem), Live Q&A;
3	Control: buckets, EMI, family	Carousel (EMI Burden), Reel (scripts), Newsletter
4	Build: buffer, goals, Day-30 results	Carousel (30 days), Reel (before and after), Challenge recap

Lead magnets, hashtags and engagement

- **Lead magnets:** Leak Score calculator, 7-Day UPI Audit sheet, Subscription Audit, Salary Template by income.
- **Hashtags:** #SalaryReset30 #WhereDidMySalaryGo #MoneyLeakScore #SalaryHalfLife #IndianPersonalFinance #UPIAudit #LifestyleInflation #EMIBurden
- **Engagement prompts:** "Comment your Salary Half-Life day." "What's the biggest leak you found?" "Which bucket is hardest for you?"
- **Challenge format:** invite followers to post their Day-1 and Day-30 numbers with #SalaryReset30.

WATCH OUT | Stay trustworthy

Creator compliance checklist. Finance content carries responsibility:

- Say clearly that it is educational and not personalised advice.
- Do not recommend specific securities, funds or schemes unless you hold the required registration. Check SEBI's current rules on investment advice and influencers, and your platform's policies.
- Disclose affiliate links and sponsorships.
- Do not promise returns or outcomes.
- Label every example as fictional or hypothetical, as this book does.

BONUS 5

The One-Page Cheat Sheet

Print it. Stick it on the wall. Review it every salary day.

Your 3-number dashboard	Formula	Why it matters
Leak Score	$\text{Recurring unnecessary spend} \div \text{take-home} \times 100$	Where money escapes
EMI Burden	$\text{Debt payments} \div \text{take-home} \times 100$	How much is already spoken for
Runway	$\text{Safety buffer} \div \text{essential monthly expenses}$	How many months you can handle a shock

Extra metrics	Formula
Salary Half-Life	Day when half your salary has left your account
Raise Capture Rate	$(\text{New surplus} - \text{old surplus}) \div \text{raise} \times 100$
Hourly Life Cost	$\text{Price} \div \text{your take-home per working hour}$
Annualiser	$\text{Monthly price} \times 12$

Ten moves in ten minutes

1. Open last month's bank statement.
2. Circle the five largest non-essential expenses.
3. Cancel one subscription.
4. Delete one shopping or delivery app's saved card.
5. Write your take-home salary at the top of a page.
6. Draw five boxes: Live, Pay, Protect, Build, Enjoy.
7. Put a rupee amount in each box (they must add up to your salary).
8. Set one standing instruction for the day after salary.
9. Calendar a 10-minute review for the first Sunday of the month.
10. Tell one person your goal.

KEY IDEA

Small, repeated, visible. That is the whole system.

CLOSING

Now Every Rupee Has a Job

The book is done. The system is yours.

When you began, the question was **“Where did my salary go?”**

By now you can answer it. You know your Leak Score and your EMI Burden. You have five buckets with real numbers in them. You have a safety buffer under construction, three named goals, and a salary-day routine that does the hard part for you.

Next month, the salary will arrive again. What will be different is that it will arrive into a plan.

Your ten-minute monthly review

- Compare planned vs actual in each bucket (a habit even RBI’s financial-awareness material recommends).
- Recalculate Leak Score and EMI Burden.
- Update safety-buffer progress.
- Check upcoming irregular expenses.
- Review goals; adjust amounts if life has changed.
- Decide one thing to improve next month.

You don’t need a bigger salary first. You need to see the salary you already have.

Thank you for reading, and more importantly, for doing the work.

The Calculators

Every formula is transparent. Use a calculator or a spreadsheet.

Calculator	Formula	Worked example
Salary Leak (monthly)	Recurring unnecessary expenses	₹3,000 a month
Salary Leak (annual)	Monthly leak × 12	₹3,000 × 12 = ₹36,000
Leak Score	Leak ÷ take-home × 100	₹3,000 ÷ ₹30,000 = 10%
Expense Annualiser	Monthly price × 12	₹799 × 12 = ₹9,588
EMI Burden	Debt payments ÷ take-home × 100	₹13,000 ÷ ₹40,000 = 32.5%
Emergency Fund	Essential expenses × months	₹18,000 × 3 = ₹54,000
Savings Rate	Savings ÷ take-home × 100	₹3,000 ÷ ₹30,000 = 10%
Lifestyle Inflation	Compare (income – spending) then vs now	Gap ₹5,000 → ₹5,000 after a raise = no progress
Financial Freedom Gap	Required monthly surplus – current monthly surplus	₹6,500 – ₹2,000 = ₹4,500

Monthly Budget Sheet

WORKSHEET | This month's plan vs actual

Bucket	Planned	Actual	Difference
Must Live			
Must Pay			
Must Protect – safety buffer			
Must Protect – irregular fund			
Must Build			
Can Enjoy			
Total (= take-home)			

Financial Goals Worksheet

WORKSHEET | Goals

Goal	Why it matters	Target	Date	Monthly

The Monthly Money Meeting (10 minutes)

- Review last month's five buckets.
- Name one win.
- Name one leak.
- Check upcoming irregular expenses.
- Confirm transfers for next salary day.

APPENDIX A

Glossary

Term	Meaning
Allocation	Deciding in advance where each rupee will go.
Asset	Something you own that has value or produces income.
Debt payment	The amount you pay each month toward loans and credit.
Diversification	Spreading money across different things to reduce the impact of any one failing.
EMI	Equated Monthly Instalment: a fixed monthly loan payment.
Emergency fund	Easily accessible money for urgent, unexpected needs.
Inflation	The general rise in prices over time.
Liquidity	How quickly something can be turned into cash without losing value.
Revolving credit	Borrowing you can carry from month to month, such as a credit-card balance.
SIP	Systematic Investment Plan: investing a fixed amount at regular intervals.
Take-home salary	What reaches your bank account after deductions.

Research and Sources

For every important figure: what it says, what it means, and what it does **not** mean.

WATCH OUT

Publisher’s note: figures and statements below were compiled from research notes. Before publishing, check each against the original source and update to the latest release. Official statistics are revised often.

Claim	Source	What it means	What it does NOT mean
Households set aside about 15% of monthly income as savings and about 9% as investments; about 36% of market investors had moderate or high product knowledge	SEBI Investor Survey 2025 (released Jan 2026)	Descriptive survey results about surveyed households	Not a recommended savings or investment rate for any household
Awareness of securities-market products is high (about 63%); household participation is much lower (about 9.5%); most households low risk-tolerance (about 79.7%)	SEBI Investor Survey 2025	Awareness and participation differ	Not evidence that low risk tolerance is a mistake, or that everyone should invest in markets
UPI handles billions of transactions every month	NPCI UPI product statistics (monthly)	Digital payments are deeply embedded in daily life	Not proof that UPI causes overspending
Average monthly per-capita consumption expenditure about ₹4,122 (rural) and ₹6,996 (urban); food about 47% and 40% respectively	MoSPI HCES 2023–24 fact sheet	National consumption context	Not a salary-budget recommendation
Budgeting means planning future income and expenses and comparing planned with actual	RBI financial-awareness (FAME) booklet	Official definition of the practice	Not a specific percentage rule
Automatic enrolment can raise saving participation, with smaller long-run effects in some recent studies	NBER research on automatic enrolment	Defaults and automation influence behaviour	Not a guarantee; effects vary
People sort money into mental categories that influence decisions	Behavioural-economics literature on mental accounting (e.g. work of Richard Thaler)	A well-documented tendency	Not a rule that applies equally to everyone

Claim	Source	What it means	What it does NOT mean
Buffett on early learning, saving and long-term thinking; spending vs status	Berkshire Hathaway annual meeting transcripts and recordings	Illustrative public statements	Not financial advice for you
Gates on goals, measurement and philanthropy	Gates Notes and Gates Foundation publications	Illustrative approach to intentional allocation	Not a recommendation to donate any amount
Affluent households often live below their means and plan spending (prodigious accumulators of wealth)	Stanley and Danko, The Millionaire Next Door (1996)	A pattern in a US sample from a specific period	Not a guarantee, and not India-specific data
Buffett reported to have built most wealth later in life and to live in a house bought in 1958; Sam Walton reported to have driven an old pickup	Widely reported biographical sources (e.g. Buffett biography and Walton's autobiography); verify originals	Illustrations of patience and modest consumption	Not instructions to copy
Musk on personal consumption	2022 TED interview (use the original video or official transcript)	Illustrative of consumption vs ownership	Not a lifestyle to copy

Official sources to use for updates

- RBI (rbi.org.in): financial awareness, inflation, banking rules
- SEBI (sebi.gov.in): investor education, survey reports, adviser registration
- NPCI (npci.org.in): UPI statistics
- MoSPI (mospi.gov.in): consumption and inflation data
- IRDAI (irdai.gov.in): insurance regulation
- Income Tax Department (incometax.gov.in): current tax rules
- PFRDA (pfrda.org.in): pension products

Final Notice

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